

CALIFORNIA PASS

★ 4.8/5 (73 reviews) Silverton, [Colorado](#) (San Juan County) Last Updated: 07/04/2024

Difficulty - Mandatory
3 - MODERATE

Difficulty - Optional
3 - MODERATE

Reported as of 06/01/2026
Partially Open

Distance
4.29 mi

Duration (one-way)
About 2 hours

Highest Elevation
12923 ft

Shape of Trail
Straight Through

Typically Open
07/01 - 11/01

Best Direction
N/A

Official Trail Name
San Juan County Road 9 and 19

Nearest Town
Silverton

Nearest Services
Silverton

Management Agency
Bureau of Land Management

District
Gunnison Field Office

TRAIL EXPERIENCE

- Altitude
- Forest
- ★ Iconic
- Mine
- Overland

California Pass is a historic four-wheel-drive road near Silverton, Colorado. It began with a purpose - to find and transport gold. Today, it is a pleasurable route offering scenic vistas of the San Juan Mountains with abundant, deeply rich, and colorful wildflowers. From the top of California Pass at 12,963 feet, look northwest for a fantastic view of the shimmering aquamarine Lake Como. The eastern side of California Pass offers glimpses of one of the most booming mining areas Colorado had to offer in the late 1800s, with the well-preserved ghost town of [Animas Forks](#) and the Frisco Mill. It is a perfect trail to combine with so many other trails that southwestern Colorado is known for and for anyone looking to get comfortable driving on shelf roads for the first time.

Recommended Vehicle:

Stock SUV with High Clearance and 4 Low

Concerns:

- ✓

None
- ✓

Width
- ✓

No Full Size
- ✓

Height
- ✓

Body Damage
- ✓

Short Wheelbase Only
- ✓

Narrow Shelf Road
- ✓

Mild Off Camber
- ✓

Moderate Off Camber
- ✓

Extreme Off Camber
- ✓

Impassable When Wet
- ✓

Deep Sand
- ✓

Mud
- ✓

Pinstriping
- ✓

High Water Crossings

Summary:

This trail gets its rating from the obstacle at Waypoint 3.

Mandatory **3 - MODERATE**

The hardest part of the trail that you **cannot bypass - you have to drive it.**

Optional **3 - MODERATE**

The hardest part of the trail that is **purely optional - you can bypass it.**

TRAIL NAVIGATION

California Pass can be run in either direction. As described here, it starts from Animas Forks and [County Road 2](#), up and over California Pass, and down to Lake Como, where it meets the end of [Poughkeepsie Gulch](#) and [Hurricane Pass](#). There are no significant obstacles along its 4.3 miles, but the trail does gain 1,800 feet in elevation with one-vehicle-wide shelf sections that are a mix of packed dirt, embedded rock, and loose scattered rocks. At the top of the pass, there's just enough room for a handful of vehicles to park and quickly turn around. It is suitable for those learning to drive on shelf roads. A high-clearance vehicle with 4Low gearing is recommended.

1. Trailhead (0 mi)





The trail begins at the ghost town of **Animas Forks** and Waypoint 12 of **County Road 2**. In 1876, the Franciscan missionaries Dominguez and Escalante recorded the name of the river below California Gulch as "El Rio de las Animas," translated to "River of Souls." In the 1870s, the camp at the bottom of California Gulch, where the three branches come together, was called 'Three Forks' and 'Forks of the Animas,' later becoming "Animas Forks" when the first cabin was built in 1873. By 1883, there were over 450 residents that mined in the area during the summer months. Every winter, the town would vacate to warmer and more hospitable towns.

Animas Forks is worth the time to walk around. The old homes are open to walk inside. Please respect this area and do not remove any artifacts.

2. Frisco Mill (0.6 mi)



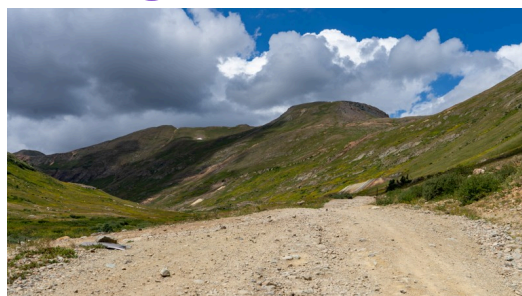
The trail passes the imposing Frisco Mill. Constructed in 1912, Frisco Mill, with its massive post and beam construction, is an unusual example of a prefabricated industrial building. Its pieces were pre-cut, pre-fit, and coded with numbers and letters before being shipped to the site for assembly. At its peak, the complex had 40 employees. With the ore exhausted, the operation was shut down in the 1920s.

3. Obstacle (1.02 mi)



A shallow, rounded obstacle requires high clearance. The remainder of the trail is rocky and occasionally steep.

4. Picayune and Placer Gulches Trailhead (1.16 mi)



At this point, the trail intersects with the **Picayune and Placer Gulches** trail, which is worth exploring if you have time. Continue straight to follow California Pass.

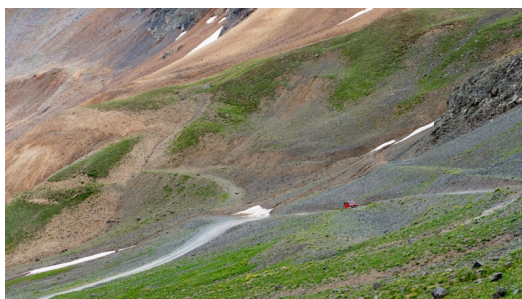


5. Scenic (2.45 mi)



As the road ascends the eastern side of California Pass, the expansive and colorful California Gulch extends eastward. Wildflowers are abundant in this area in late July and early August due to the amount of sunshine and moisture. The trail continues to follow the West Fork of the Animas River until it reaches the first set of switchbacks.

6. Start Switchbacks (3.17 mi)



The trail begins climbing out of California Gulch. These switchbacks are not difficult, but a low-range transfer case takes the stress off of your drivetrain during the climb and descent of the pass.

7. Mine and Narrow Shelf (3.75 mi)



There is a lack of historical records of the Mountain Queen Mine, but it was a gold mine. There is room to park if you want to walk around before making your way up the narrowest portion of the shelf road to the pass. Look ahead for oncoming traffic, as this section of the shelf road is only wide enough for one vehicle.

8. Summit (3.93 mi)



The summit of California Pass has spectacular views in all directions. It is a good idea at this point to look for uphill traffic ascending the west side of the pass to avoid contending with oncoming traffic on the trip down. You can see the final shelf road portion of this trail heading down to Lake Como.



The end of the trail is located near Lake Como at the intersection of [Hurricane Pass](#) to the west and [Poughkeepsie Gulch](#) to the north.

✓ Not Allowed

There is no camping along the California Pass trail, and many signs along the route state this. Lodging is available in Silverton. Dispersed camping is located on the short spur of [County Road 26](#). Improved camping can be found 4.3 miles south of Animas Forks at the former townsite of Eureka. That area has large flat camping spots suitable for large RVs and offers modern pit toilets.